IX—Doubt

‘Akbar, a king like Alexander, attained his every wish.’

– Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 6

There was a new confidence in Akbar when he returned to Fatehpur from Patna. In the first few months of 1575, he did two things that would not only cement the foundations of his own reign, but create a blueprint for rule that would endure centuries after Akbar’s demise.

First, after years of hedging by his nobility, Akbar finally pushed through his administrative reforms – every bit of land in the realm would belong to the crown, there would be no more fiefs; and every bit of farmed land would be remeasured – not with the customary rope, but with bamboo rods, for greater accuracy.[1] As for the fief-holders, they were mansabdars now, with ranks and responsibilities, for which they would be paid a salary. Thus, a man might hold a rank between 10 and 5000, the number indicating how many cavalrymen he was obliged to provide the emperor when called upon to do so, and his salary calculated on how much it would cost to maintain so many men and horses – and, of course, the mansabdar himself.

Second, Akbar began to host weekly theological debates in his newly built Ibadat Khana, a ‘house of worship’ to which the emperor invited clerics, scholars and believers of various (for the moment, only Muslim) sects for night-long debates of increasing acrimony.

It is hard to say which of the two decisions was more controversial, though both were born of ideas whose time had come.

It was now, writes the modern historian Ali Anooshahr, in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, that the Ottoman, Safavid and Mughal empires all moved from ‘the war band . . . to a bureaucratic absolutist “state”’.[2] Presumably, this was at least partly because there was only so far an empire could run on shields full of hidden treasure shared between warlords. It also indicated, however, a new focus on the monarch of this evolving state as the source of its legitimacy and authority. This was, as many historians have argued, the logic and the genius of the mansabdari system. Warlords like the Uzbeks or the Mirzas drew sustenance from the strength of their own arms and that of their clans; a mansabdar owed his salary, his authority, and therefore his loyalty, to the shahinshah.